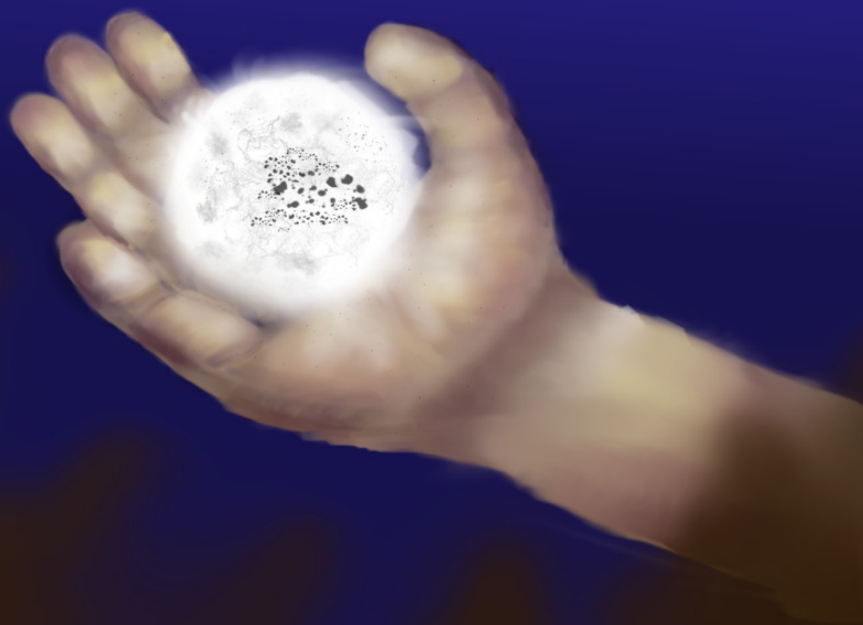




Prologue

A mind incapable of being reprogrammed is a vulnerable one. But you are never more vulnerable when you are being reprogrammed! Whether this is self-inflicted or is done so by your environment is of little consequence. After you're in a more stable state, can you more closely represent what reality is?

Ether's Bicentennial address 2247

The sun burned brightly even though it was an early spring day. In particular it seemed the rays of light had chosen a particular person that day, casually sitting on a bench in a small park. Perhaps it was the fact that he stood out particularly against the background. The brightest of green colors around him, against his casual black outfit which blended well with his skin. He remembered not exactly how he got there... by the time he became aware of himself, it seemed an age of the universe had gone by.

CHAPTER

First Day

[I] was sixteen and already bored of the assembly before it started.

His mother — mom — had dropped him and his sister at the gate without a word, which was not like her.

[IA] found him by the lockers. "Your sister okay? She looked like she'd seen a ghost."

He shrugged it off. He was good at shrugging things off – better than he was at being right about them.

CHAPTER

The Lecture

[II] had taken the professor's course three times now in different

forms, and never seen the slide that went up that morning.

It was not on the syllabus. It was, as far as she could tell, not on anyone's syllabus.

The visiting lecturer introduced himself only as [S].

CHAPTER

The Message

That night [I] logged on and [IB] was already typing.

He stared at the message for a long time.